

Some gentlemen were so busy applauding the players on stage that they did not notice they were being robbed

LESSONS IN LIFTING

London was full of thieves called cutpurses, many of whom worked in well-organized gangs. In 1585, a school for boy cutpurses was discovered in a London ale house at Billingsgate. The school was run by an ex-merchant called Mr. Wotton, who taught boys to steal by getting them to lift coins from a purse with bells attached to it. Boys had to learn to take the coins without ringing the bells.

Cutting a purse was called "nipping a bung" in criminal slang



The cutpurse waits for the right moment to cut the purse strings

A gentleman's well-cut clothes stood out in the yard, where the poorest members of the audience gathered, and were likely to attract the attention of a cutpurse

Pants were worn tucked inside boots for riding

COUNTRY GENTLEMAN

Many gentlemen rode up to London from the countryside on business and called at the playhouses for some entertainment. Visitors from outside London were less aware than city people of the risk of being robbed by a cutpurse. Robberies took place regularly in the playhouses. This provided the Lord Mayor with an argument for closing them, although he exaggerated the number of crimes committed. In 1597, he wrote to the Privy Council, to warn it that playhouses were meeting places for "thieves, horse stealers, and plotters of treason."

Boys made good cutpurses because they were small enough not to be noticed and had nimble fingers

ROBBING PLACE

Cutpurses got their name because they would cut the strings that tied a purse to its owner's belt. Playhouses were ideal places for the cutpurses to work because they were so crowded and everyone there was concentrating on the stage. Despite this, cutpurses were sometimes caught in the act and beaten up by angry members of the audience.